

PALM

Since the introduction of the first Palm Pilot in 1996, Palm has been an immensely popular platform for handhelds. It enjoys tremendous support from third-party application developers, and there aren't too many things that you can't do on it—from basic PIM-level tasks, business tools, games, to accessing the Internet and even wireless connectivity!

Palm Zire

Using post-its? Grow up to Zire!

The entry-level PDA from Palm, the Palm Zire is compact and elegant. It runs Palm OS 4.1. The Zire features a 160 x 160 pixel greyscale screen, a glossy white front, with the rear done in grey.

Powered by a 16 MHz Dragonball EZ processor, the Zire has 1.8 MB of RAM for programs and data, and 2 MB non-flash-upgradeable ROM. 1.8 MB is more than enough for storing quite a few contacts, memos and calendar entries. However, if you want to work with several applications at the same time, or need advanced features such as a wireless connection, you need to look further.

Screen contrast is good, but it lacks a backlight; however, this means that battery life is extremely good. There are two scroll buttons, but just two application buttons for contacts and the calendar. Dedicated buttons for Memos and To-do lists are missing, so you can't run games that require four buttons. There's no expansion slot either. Syncing is done using the mini-USB cable, or using IrDA. Since there's no cradle, you need to tap the star button on the silkscreen to initiate HotSync. The plastic digitiser layer on the screen is fairly responsive, and text entry using Graffiti is easy. The Graffiti area silkscreen includes Clock and Contrast icons, and a star icon that launches HotSync by default.

The bundled CD contains Palm Desktop, Chapura Pocket Mirror for synchronisation with MS-Outlook, and four games.

Overall, the Palm Zire is a very appealing package, considering its ease of use, and the price tag of Rs 7,500. You can get it about Rs 500 less in the grey market.

Palm Zire

A-

Palm Zire		A-
Performance	    	
Features	    	
Ease of use	    	
Value for money	    	

Price: Rs 7,500
+ Good value for money
- No backlight

Palm Zire 71

Carry on chic

The Palm Zire 71 is one of the best deals you can get for a PDA today. It's powered by a good processor, and is backed by an obscene amount of quality software. With a funky blue-and-silver colour combination, it comes with a healthy 320 x 320 pixel screen and more than 64,000 colours. The screen is very readable, exceptionally clear, uniformly lit and bright. The processor is blazingly fast for applications and games. Ably supporting the power offered is the latest Palm OS 5.2.1—complete with excellent colour support and faster in-built applications. There's 16 MB of internal memory.

The button layout is a pleasure to work with. The handheld comes bundled with a good selection of software, including an SMS application, Audible Player for audio books, RealOne Player

and several others.

The Zire 71 comes with an SD Memory slot, an Infra-red port and the standard Palm Universal Connector. The handheld sits on its cradle via this connector, which can also be used to connect to other peripherals, such as a modem and a keyboard. The bundled software can talk transparently with Microsoft Outlook, and can maintain a single data point for all PIM tasks.

There are issues of course. If you go multimedia-happy, the battery won't see you further than 4 to 5 hours; the stylus could have found a better home, away from the power button; the rear of the unit is slippery. And it comes across as a less-than-average music solution.

But these are small niggles at worst—the snappy processor and stable OS make the unit a joy to work with. Reading an e-book finally becomes an enjoyable proposition. While the software bundle is good, the library available online is breathtaking.

The Zire 71 is a great buy for its price, it can be yours for as little as Rs 23,000. A small addendum to sway opinions: it can also take photographs! Though the resolution is not so pleasing at 640 x 480, it's a camera nonetheless.

Palm Zire 71		B+
Performance	    	
Features	    	
Ease of use	    	
Value for money	    	



How We Tested

We had an assortment of platforms for this evaluation, so we didn't compare them head-to-head in terms of pure performance. The broad parameters we focussed on were features, bundled applications and ease of use.

Features: We looked at storage space; type of screen—whether it was colour or greyscale, and whether it was backlit; expansion options provided, such as an SD card slot; connectivity options provided, such as IrDA; Bluetooth support; battery type and life; and extras such as a docking cradle, built-in speaker, camera and so on.

Bundled applications: We looked at the applications that came pre-loaded with the PDA, as well as those on the accompanying CD.

User friendliness: In the ease-of-use department, we looked at the interface, number of hard buttons, and whether they were user-customisable or not.